

Preface

At some point between 2020 and 2022, I convinced myself that riding roller coasters is beneficial to the human body's nervous system. I arrived at this notion with absolutely no research. Everything I claim about roller coasters in this here Google Document is purely anecdotal.

I think I subconsciously birthed the idea due to a previous phase I went through where I would take only cold showers. I would stand in the shower and *then* turn it on. While most people, including myself, would classify that as psychopathic behavior, I somehow convinced myself that it was beneficial. One day, I was asked to explain myself, and I said, "Something about really cold water hitting your brain, like your head, directly has to do something, like, stimulating or like, because your nervous system just totally wakes up and, like, initiates creativity, you know?"¹

Even after looking online and reading multiple arguments for and against the idea, my self-created perspective of high-intensity physical thrill being 'good for my body' never faded. I thought it only made sense to give your inner body the occasional dose of neurological eustress, a biological workout that you don't know that you need every once in a while.

¹ I can't recall any notable health benefits, so I neither endorse nor oppose it. I fell out of that phase after about 6 months.

Sober: American Eagle

Now, in 2024, me and a few friends received season passes to Six Flags Great America in Gurnee, Illinois, for the summer. This season pass was given to me completely for free; I never even sought it out. How? Mind your business, that's how. Like I said, it was given to me, meaning I didn't produce it and therefore will not assume the position to expose others.

On the first trip, we arrived about 2 hours before the park closed to get our season passes set up and our pictures taken. Afterward, we only had time to make it onto one or two rides, one of which was a roller coaster called the "American Eagle".

It had been about 2 years or so since I had been on a roller coaster, so I had nerves building up. My friend and I are seated and secured in the only vacant car remaining, which is the very front. As we climbed, the potential energy was like a forced kind of foreplay.² I felt excitement, good excitement, until 15 seconds passed and we were still climbing, which is about when I began to regret things. Finally at the top, we're tipping forward comedically slowly, and absolute hell ensues. The drop was extensive and not a vibe. Kinetic energy was a ruthless sadist. For kinetic energy to really fuck, though, massive potential energy is required.³ Potential energy was like a really sweet lover, all thoughtful and tender because it was long and drawn out, albeit a little overpassionate towards the end, but now I see why. Kinetic energy came home from a day job, furious and horny, put me on all fours, and gripped my hair with a tight fist while fucking me like a pony. I swear, every other roller coaster I've ever been on, I would get accustomed to (which would even become enjoyable) soon after the drop. This was not the same. It kind of got worse, to be honest. It definitely had to do with being in the front car, something I don't think I've ever done until then.

In no way was I worried that the ride was going to collapse or break down or do anything like send our screaming train off into the Trix yogurt-looking sky, airborne and long-arc'd like Santa Claus, floating like a frisbee, seen from miles away as a caterpillar's crawling silhouette over a gibbous moon straight out of a

² (Between me and the roller coaster, not my friend).

³ (Like I said, foreplay).

Disney movie, and anticlimactically smash into some trees near a highway. I was not worried about that at all.

Of course I was fine, and everybody else was fine when it was all over, but instead of realizing that maybe I'm not as big of a fan of roller coasters as I used to be, I thought of it like, 'Yeah, it's been a while, so I'm a little rusty. Gotta get my tolerance back up,' as if an athlete of some sort. It was genuinely petrifying, but I'd be back in less than a week.

Sober: Food Court

Something like 5 days later, it's sunny and sticky hot. I decide to go by myself. I leave my house early so that I can spend my whole day at SFGA. I'm genuinely excited, but not about the roller coasters. I think I'm more looking forward to spending a bright day outdoors, away from home, independently, and with no set agenda. Each time I think about riding another roller coaster, I get a brief passing feeling in my stomach that I feel, as the reader or listener, you know what I'm talking about, and I don't need to find a clever way to describe it.

I arrive right at the opening hour, so parking is like taking an easy shit.

I walk up to the SFGA employee who scans my season pass, and suddenly, I feel the urge to tell him, "Look! I got a season pass—for free!" Of course, not in a bragging way, it's just that I wouldn't be here if it weren't for that. Also, I kind of just felt like telling someone, but thankfully I kept my mouth shut once I remembered: (1) he works here, and that means he is one of the *last* people to find this place exciting, and (2) who would really give a shit? He doesn't know me, and I'm free to fuck off and ride every roller coaster as many times as I want for the entire day, let alone the summer—while he has to stand here and perform the same action and say the same greeting as many times necessary for the entire day, and probably the summer.

Once inside, the vibe turned kind of dutiful, like, 'I'm here to ride roller coasters and exercise my inner anatomy with bursts of manufactured adrenaline, so what the hell am I waiting for?'

On a two-legged board to my right, I find the park's map, and it is satisfyingly illustrated. At first, it's hard for me to read because there is so much to it, so many little numbers in color-coded squares that link to a massive legend overtop a physical layout of the property and its rides. It very quickly becomes pleasing—in fact, it's perfect. If it were less detailed, it would be a joke of a park map, hard to be taken seriously, a failed reproduction by some nonemployee on the internet, but if it were any more detailed, it would be too intense, visually too crowded, and even harder to navigate. It is balanced and colorful, as all things should be.

When my gaze meets the American Eagle, I scan its illustration for the steep drop in the track—you know, the one where if you're in the front car, the kinetic

energy will hold your jaw open and skull-fuck you? Yeah—nowhere to be found. I consciously blink, then move on.⁴

*Author's note: Hi, it has just been brought to my attention that the American Eagle is 127 ft. high and has a max speed of 66 mph, while the Goliath is 164 ft. high and has a max speed of 72 mph. I of course recognize that the Goliath being 37 feet higher is no small difference, but I'm just saying they illustrate it like some caricature's boner, while the American Eagle's is hardly a lump.

It's still early, so foot traffic is scarce, and as I make my way through the food court, I am an easy target for the opening staff behind the counters of their massive carnival game cubicles. Every game host is wearing a harsh sapphire blue polo and khaki shorts. When they invite me over to try my luck at their game, they are delightful and come across as real human beings. I politely decline because that shit is rigged, and I need to hurry up and make sure I ride a roller coaster before I somehow manage not to.

While most are *DC Comics* themed, the games themselves are your typical county fair games like Duck Pond, Ring Toss, and Water Guns, as well as more skill-based games like Basketball Shooting and Balloon Popping. Also available are redemption games like Skee Ball, Whack-A-Mole, and Strongman, which don't require staff.⁵

The basketball host keeps a dialogue going with me while he spins a basketball in both hands and stops it with a catch. He does this consistently and without a set rhythm. As I continue through the food court, he is practically yelling to keep the dialogue going. He was, basically—in a fun and playful manner—not taking no for an answer. He was challenging me in ways like, “What? You don't wanna shoot hoops??” followed by, “I know you got a sweet jump shot, man, come on.” I joke back and forth with him (from, at one point, more than 50 ft. away) and tell him I might have a go at it later.

I genuinely believe he was just having a bit of fun—fun for himself, his coworkers, and even me—but that doesn't mean I didn't cringe inside when I

⁴ For a second, I actually wondered if I was mistaking the American Eagle for the “Goliath”, whose drop is illustrated like a cursive lower-case L or a high-amplitude sine wave.

⁵ Redemption games are games where, if you win, you are rewarded with tickets. Once you have enough tickets, you can redeem them for an actual prize. Unfortunately, the ticket-prize value ratio is ridiculous. It will always be easier and cheaper to buy said prize with currency instead of the tickets. It's not a heartbreaking concept to get your head around unless you are a child, AKA the main demographic.

realized I went the wrong way and had to come back through the food court and see him less than 2 minutes later. I endure the sales pitch all over again, where he goes, “Hey man! Back already?? I knew you’d come around, bro.”

Sober: X-Flight

I wanted to start off with a roller coaster that I was certain would feel like a suitable warm-up and not another surprise ass-clapping.⁶ Then, I thought it might actually be good to start with something more intense because that way, it would keep all the other roller coasters from feeling like a step up, which might be too intimidating to convince myself that I'm having fun. I overthought this a little bit longer before eventually deciding on the "X-Flight."

When I go to the entrance, an SFGA employee stands guard of the two pathways. I approach him, and he says, "Someone threw up..." I respond as casually as I hope I'm supposed to, and he adds, "A little bit got on my shoes," as he leans back on both heels and looks down at his feet for a little longer than a second.

Eventually, they reopen, and I get on the X-Flight, featuring the voice of the man DMX himself.⁷ The X-Flight is a wing coaster model, meaning the roller coaster track lives in between pairs of riders, where there is nothing above or below them. Instead of your typical roller coaster restraints, there is a vest restraint, a belt restraint, and bars to hold onto. I suppose, in some ways, not being at the front of a rattling minecart going 65 mph on wooden boards made the experience better than the American Eagle's.

But that doesn't mean X didn't give it to me—this one had a loop in it, which means I experienced centripetal force, a suppressed kink for the kinetic energy, which, to be honest, wasn't so bad.

Though, after I got off the X-Flight, I went to the "Demon," where I was back in the seated cars, and the kinetic energy was no longer shy about its centripetal force fetish.

I was still trying to shake nerves after two rides, still waiting to cross the threshold to where it all became fun again. It was only a few years ago that this was all a blast. Not seconds later, I spot a small sign that says 'Beer'.

Ca.12:00pm, I pay \$15.00 USD for a beer at Steelworks Pub in the DC Universe. It's a big beer—actually, it's 2 beers in a giant cup, so I wasn't that mad about paying so much.⁸

⁶ (q.v. *Sober: American Eagle*)

⁷ R.I.P.

⁸ But still, holy shit, man.

I took a moment to sit in the sun on a bench against the pool of water in the Carousel Plaza. Facing me was a facility with a Cash to Card Kiosk, Restrooms, Package Pick-Up, and Wheelchair & Stroller Rental. I lounged with a posture that had to seem obnoxious, and drank up while savoring the vibes. Just vibing. Often, I'd hear the sound of young children screaming or crying or something, but thanks to my aura and alcohol, I felt genuinely superior to the commotion, so I went on existing happily.

—My Personal and Impressive SFGA Ride Stats and Statuses—

Throughout my day, I hit the X-Flight, Demon, Superman Ultimate Flight (2x), Whizzer,⁹ and Batman.

Rides that I currently¹⁰ refuse to go on are: Goliath, The Joker, Raging Bull,¹¹ The Flash Vertical Velocity, and any type of tall dropping mechanism that people call a ‘ride’.

The Viper is a *maybe*.

Swings: Probably.

American Eagle: Yes, but only if seated in the middle of the train and with peer(s).

River Rocker: no

Carousel: probably

Carousel with an ice cream cone: a high-pitched, definite yes.

Spinning tea cups: Yes, but only if really drunk and with peer(s).¹²

There’s one roller coaster that I just pretend doesn’t exist: the “Maxx Force,” and here is why:

Firstly, the track looks like balled-up metal wire, like a Rottweiler ripped out some kid’s braces, chewed on them, and spit them out in a back alley. It’s definitely part of the design, and that is something that I refuse to underestimate. Its height and top speed slightly surpass the Goliath’s. It’s white and gray, which makes me think that it’s faster or more high-tech or newer, or like it’s so crazy that it couldn’t even be painted for safety reasons and it had to *only* be made of bare steel—or worse, that’s what they *wanted* to communicate because the designer felt like it accurately represented the energy of the ride. Additionally, the steel white track is supported by these gray-blue skeletal-frame foundational beams that appear as if they are contorting inward. Extra support like that tells me that any cool-looking or intimidating design simply didn’t live up to the experience because it’s so gnarly—or worse, they *wanted* to have some type of stylistic design, but the ride

⁹ Good name for a family coaster.

¹⁰ (absolutely)

¹¹ So far, all violent characters. Coincidence?

¹² (Peer(s) must also be drunk)

was so insane, they thought it would be funny to not hype it up with any kind of design *at all*.

Next, it's the name. What the fuck does "Maxx Force" mean? There are two x's, which feels like it sort of throws shade at the X-Flight, which means this is some type of extra-X-force to the maximum shit.¹³

Lastly, it's the name, again. The fear that I associate with this roller coaster is different because I can't mentally attribute it to Superman or Batman or any villain. There's no comic book cape-wearing asshole that I can blame for the dread that this roller coaster would give me. I also don't know anyone named Max that is spelled with two x's. Would you trust a Max with two x's? Likewise.

¹³ I would consider it if there were three x's and you didn't have to be a certain height, only a certain age.

Tipsy: Always Meet Your Heroes

24 oz. plastic cup of cold beer in my hand, sunscreen inside my glasses, pocket possessions digging silently into my iliotibial band. Love.

Strolling on smooth dark asphalt under the open blue dome. Yes, it is hot with a capital H, but I am refreshed when I walk through the sensor for the automatic mist sprayer; my being is hydrated, and my lenses are speckled as I wander into Hometown Square. *Love*.

How could it get any better?

I see a short line of people waiting to have their picture taken with the one and only Bugs Bunny. Love.

Bugs is moving; he's real and as friendly as you'd imagine. He's posing with the kids and giving thumbs up and hugging them, and the kids are smiling widely and truly elated. Love.

Bugs doesn't speak, though. All of his communication is done through hand gestures.¹⁴

I see the kid in front of me shooting the shit with Bugs and hugging him, which makes me jealous.¹⁵

Finally, it's my turn; I hand my camera-ready phone to the lovely SFGA staff. I walk up to Bugs and can tell *immediately* that he fucks with me; I've got my Locs, cargo shorts, and my white tank top with a fading logo of 'Paper Street Soap Company' from *Fight Club*. Love.

Bugs sticks his arm out far for a fist bump, but I walk past it and miss it. I fucking *miss* it. I don't know what happened; I have no clue why—I think because his gloves are so puffy, I didn't distinguish the gesture in time.¹⁶ I go right up to him, say what's up, throw my arm around his shoulder, and pull him close—all of which is more aggressive than intended.

It isn't until I'm smiling and staring straight ahead at my phone's camera that I realize I might be a little tipsy. Love?

¹⁴ It's probably for the better. Hearing some guy try to be Bugs without doing a flawless impression would shatter the illusion completely.

¹⁵ (of the kid, not Bugs)

¹⁶ I'm also two double-beers deep on an empty stomach in 90°F+ weather—I'm making excuses, I know... I left Bugs hanging. Not love.

Looking back at the picture hours later, I notice on the building behind us a perfectly centered LGBTQ flag hanging directly above me and Bugs... True love.

Drunk: Batman™: The Ride

It's a long line to the Batman roller coaster¹⁷, but I'm genuinely enjoying it. Considering all the different Batman movies and themes that have come out over the years, I'm happy to hear Danny Elfman's film score from Tim Burton's *Batman* being used nearly 35 years after it came out.

Also, it's my favorite film score. It is sophisticated, full, and harmonically creative. There's never a dull moment to it, yet the score still breathes and takes breaks from busyness.

The theme is heroic but not brash like Superman's theme. I'm not knocking Superman, nor am I knocking such an iconic theme by—**Sudden author's note:** Holy fuck I did not know that John Williams wrote the Superman theme—I mean you no disrespect, sir.

I would try to tame my expression of my interest in Batman, which has oddly grown to an autistic level at this point, but I feel like I have to get this out...

I'll use Superman's score in contrast because he's likely considered the quintessential superhero, archetype-, appearance-, and icon-wise. Superman's theme is without a doubt more memorable and easily communicates, 'He is *super*. He is bright blue and can *fly*. He is a man of *steel* and has *powers* and laser *eyesight* and is a *hero*,' while most Batman scores, especially Elfman's, communicate brooding and a sense of taxing work that has been obsessively put in by a man with *no superpowers* to successfully become a true source of fear among the city's criminals. And when circumstances get crazy for Batman, his strength and humanity are tested, making the stakes higher and him with more to lose. Respect for Superman and all, but Batman is undeniably a more complex character, which the score admirably reflects.

Last thing I'll rant about regarding the score is what makes it impressive. The score is strictly orchestral, which is, in a way, limiting—except not to Danny. The motif rises and falls, but what Elfman does to convey various moods throughout the film, among dynamics, is change the chord(s) underneath the last note, or fall. Full authority over the mood is given to the supporting harmony carrying the motif. Elfman makes a unique use of what limitations come with a hero's theme played solely by an orchestra.

¹⁷ I am unable to recall how long, even relatively. This might have been the peak of my intoxication.

The music blasts through easily visible speakers as I inch myself along through what feels like a detour to avoid ongoing construction. The path takes you up a dog-legged staircase, where the walls are made out of black aluminum and are vertically grooved a la a shipping container. Holy fuck is it hot in here; you inhale the humidity like a sauna. Everyone in the stagnant line is sweaty, and I am drenched. I lean against the wall, and after the line moves 2 feet forward, I notice that I have left a remarkable amount of sweat on it. Even against the black surface, the shrinking beads are distinguishable within the ghost print of my arm and shoulder. I pretend to be unaware while the people behind me look at it. The only prop or set design is, ironically, a giant wall-sized fan in the duct we are all supposed to be standing in.

The Batman ride is an inverted coaster, meaning the train rides underneath the track and the seats are connected at their tops. Each car seats four riders. Once it's time to get on, a group of kids beside me are quickly delegating which one of them has to sit next to the stranger, AKA me. Eventually, they are forced to find their seats, and it seems like the verdict was more or less random. The kid who sits next to me isn't upset about it, but I can tell he feels like he's missing out on doing this great big fun activity with his friends. He moves his head around trying to find them in the following row, but the molded seats are huge like the X-Flight's, only purple, and with a mustard yellow harness that shuts him in. Its locking mechanism is convincing and loud. Little bro is stuck with me.

Something I have put off addressing in this here Google document is what it's like to get on a ride by yourself and be forced to sit next to someone who is not here by themselves but has now been isolated with you. At an amusement park, there's a 50% chance that it'll be a kid.¹⁸ And kids are weird with strangers, especially when they are at least half your age. They're all afraid—not afraid of you, but of not being with their friends *while* being with you. All of this is understandable. For me, life has progressed, and I am now on the old and scary side. What they don't know is that I'm now wishing I was with my friends too; I'm not trying to scream next to this 9-year-old boy. Why? Well, if the young boy doesn't scream in terror and I do, then I am, essentially, a wimp. True or not, the

¹⁸ Could be 80%, could be 30%, I don't actually know.

ordeal would stay in my head for well over a month, and I don't want that thank you very much.¹⁹

¹⁹ It wouldn't be an inaccurate cliché to tell the children in situations like these that "They are more scared of you than you are of them."

Faded: Justice League: Battle for Metropolis

I'm beginning to come down from my tediously maintained almost-too-drunk state from all afternoon. I don't feel good enough to enjoy another roller coaster, but I also have to drive home in an hour, so no more drinks. I fuck with the vibes in the Southwest Territory, so I sit on a bench opposite the River Rocker, a giant vessel with something like 40 people in it. It swings like a pendulum and is reminiscent of a medieval bladed execution. I momentarily lean forward and hang my head between my kneecaps. I hear the River Rocker people screaming, and it's only on their way down, which causes a sort of live stereo-panned automation of collective screams.

Also notable is the Mission Beer Garden to my right, which is nothing more than a standard sports bar. It's lively, and I don't wish to check it out any further. From where I'm sitting, its interior is surprisingly anatomic and consists of many dark shades of green. There are no families inside, and it's not even remotely thematic. There are TV screens and beers and music that easily indicate sticky tabletops. There is no purpose that I can find for its existence here, other than that it's for individual family friends who tag along with said family and eventually get tired of following them around and decide to hang back. There's quite a lot of chatter coming from within, though, so I assume people are enjoying themselves.

No one comes to Six Flags alone (as I learned firsthand), but for the few who do, is this where they go? But there is no way, no chance, that even one person would come all the way to SFGA solely to hang out at a small sports bar.²⁰ I suppose it's here for them, just in case.

To my left is the Metropolis Plaza, where the Hall of Justice lives. I go to check it out, and I wander into the line of an interactive thrill ride. The line is long, but I am greeted by an over-enthusiastic voice through the speakers:

*Lex Luthor and the Joker have teamed up to take control of Metropolis and
The Justice League needs your help!
Supergirl, The Flash, and Green Lantern have already been captured!*

²⁰ Unless it's some sort of strategy for picking up MILFs. This is a pretty likely spot for MILFs.

I imagine myself a few or too many beers deeper, flexing every muscle in my body, neck veins bulging, my frame trembling, my calf muscles grossly at full contraction, standing on my toes, eyes closed, and shouting upwards, “FUCK NO!!! FUCK NO!!!”

Once the 3-minute monologue restarts, I realize that the animatronic Cyborg (I think that’s his name?) off to the side is supposed to be the voice that’s been talking to me this whole time. He appears terribly out of sync with the audio, and his mouth doesn’t move, just his cheekbones. His hand gestures are rocky. He bounces forward and backward unnaturally, and I’m unable to make out if it’s on purpose or not. Now that I think about it, he might be broken.

A 6-seat baby blue car approaches slowly, and I am seated with 3 Hispanic children. The car is not connected to a train; it’s by itself—just like me with these kids. It’s basically 2 tiers of plastic blue slabs that can fit 2 people each—one on the bottom at the front and one raised a little higher right behind. There are no armrests or anything dividing anyone from each other in the seats, which, again, I wouldn’t even call seats.

In front of each of us is a PG-ified gun wired to the car from the bottom of what would be its magazine. It looks like an industrialized blow dryer by design. I pick it up and hold it and feel awkward because there is nothing to shoot at yet. The kids haven’t said a word to each other.

The car swivels and spins as it takes you through the ‘streets’ and ‘alleyways’ in a programmed high-speed chase. The guns don’t make sounds, just the plastic trigger that’s unsatisfyingly allowed only a half-squeeze. We shoot at the screens where mayhem is occurring, and I can’t see a reticle for shit. I’m not even fully convinced that this isn’t just a premade video that they’re showing and making it only *appear* like you’re shooting up bad guys.

I wish I could say, in the end, after a hot day of nerves and self-inflicted adrenaline, I had the most fun saving Metropolis with 3 Hispanic children, but that’s just not true. Right when the ride started moving, it officially clicked that this was weird. I mean, what am I gonna do, talk to them? Elevate their experience by chiming in? Well, (1) I’m a stranger, (2) there’s a chance that they don’t even speak English, (3) they’re definitely old enough to know that this whole Justice League thing isn’t real and that this is just an interactive ride, and (4) I’m not drunk enough.

I would be totally intruding on their fun, cramping their experience as a group, and maybe even making them uncomfortable. I think the kids themselves felt a little shy about having their own fun because of my presence. They had to pretend that I wasn't there, as did I.

There was an actual ball of fire, startling sounds, smoke machines, colored lights, moving animatronics of all kinds of villains, multiple different settings, and surround sound effects, and we got to light up Lex Luther's bald ass with our guns; yet there was little to no emotion from any of us. You could literally see it when the ride was over and it was taking us back to the start, and we were shown snapshots of our faces that were taken during the ride with our scores underneath. I scored the least, and I was visibly drained, sweaty, sunburnt, and not sober. Even after we saved Superman and Batman and we continued to pump digital-interactive bullets into Lex's limp carcass, all of our faces were flat.

I wanted to have fun, and I suppose I did, but it wasn't how it used to be, where I couldn't get enough of the rides and I wanted to experience every coaster in the park.

And but of course I needed to not be sober to do this; of course I needed to not be in my normal state of mind, a state of being where I always desire thrill. Here, I'm serving myself thrill on a golden platter, and I can't enjoy it? Perhaps I'm confusing the word 'thrill' with something else. Part of what I crave is the anticipation of the thrill, like the ritualistic preparations for drug use, foreplay before sex, the shaving and grooming and dressing myself before going out to a club, bar, party, etc., the excitement I feel on my way to see what I'm damn sure will be a remarkable film...

I admit it, here and now in this here Google Document: I had no positive sensations regarding the anticipatory feelings before the rides. Wouldn't it have been so cool to have that? Not only to enjoy it, but to be *that* guy—who just goes on roller coasters by himself because he takes on life's sensations more hardcore than the Average Joe? Whether it was good for the nervous system or not, who knows, but my brain speaks for itself.